

The Model Millionaire



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF OSCAR WILDE

Oscar Wilde was born into a distinguished Anglo-Irish family in Dublin, Ireland, in 1854. His mother's love of poetry instilled in him a lifelong devotion to literature, and he excelled early at Classics. His studies took him to Oxford in 1874, where he joined ranks with the burgeoning Aesthetic and Decadent movements, which promoted "art for art's sake." In the years after university, he broke into London high society, where his good looks, outspoken behavior, and biting wit made him a celebrity. He proved that his fame was well-earned by producing a steady stream of quality poems, stories, and plays—including the enduringly popular 1895 play [The Importance of Being Earnest](#)—that skewered the Victorian morality of his day while maintaining a light touch and a mastery of humor and irony. His 1891 novel [The Picture of Dorian Gray](#) scandalized English readers with its homoerotic undercurrents and frank promotion of artistic hedonism. The scandal proved fateful: in 1895, Wilde's personal enemies brought him to trial for "gross indecency," invoking *Dorian Gray* as evidence. They were able to prove that Wilde, married with children, had indeed been carrying on homosexual affairs with younger men—a crime at the time. Wilde was sentenced to two years of hard labor. Debilitated by his prison ordeal, Wilde made off to France upon his release, spending his final few years there in grim poverty and dying of meningitis in 1900.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Wilde's writing generally belongs to the Aesthetic and Decadent movements, which were overlapping currents in late-19th-century literary and visual arts that pushed back against the Victorian era's stifling morality and emphasis on scientific progress and rationality. Against this cold utilitarianism, Aestheticism valued "art for art's sake," while the (originally French) Decadent movement extended this philosophy into an all-purpose hedonism that found liberatory pleasure in transgression. Wilde played a major role in defining these philosophies. Some of Wilde's writings explicitly explore these ideas, while lighter pieces like "The Model Millionaire" seek simply to provide the self-contained aesthetic delight that Wilde cherished. Contrary to criticisms that Wilde's attitudes were amoral and divorced from reality, Wilde in fact maintained a lifelong interest in economic reform, and he composed substantial socialist manifestos. He felt that economic inequality impeded universal access to artistic and aesthetic pleasure, and this concern informs "The Model Millionaire," where poverty threatens to thwart Hughie's romance.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Wilde's artistic outlook was greatly influenced by the Victorian art critic Walter Pater, whose *Studies in the History of the Renaissance* exalts individual artistic refinement above all else. He was also influenced by the critic John Ruskin, whose numerous writings insist on art's power to elevate society. This tension emerges thematically in "The Model Millionaire." In the story, Wilde also gently satirizes Victorian pretensions—a theme he greatly amplifies in his dramatic masterpiece, [The Importance of Being Earnest](#). This play comedically exposes social hypocrisies around marriage and class only hinted at in "The Model Millionaire." While *Earnest* proves that Wilde transcends easy categorization, he nevertheless remains most associated with the Decadent movement. His Decadent peers include Algernon Charles Swinburne, a poet likewise fascinated by artistic extremes and transgressive sexuality. Given that these writers valued aesthetic perfection so highly, it should come as no surprise that "The Model Millionaire" features a surprise reversal of fortune: the ancient philosopher Aristotle proclaimed that such a reversal is essential to any well-constructed plot in his *Poetics*, the first and arguably greatest work of literary criticism. Furthermore, Wilde's interest in surprise endings was not unique among his contemporaries: the American short story writer O. Henry, perhaps influenced by Wilde, likewise composed brief tales of social commentary with witty twist endings, such as "The Gift of the Magi" and "The Duplicity of Hargraves."

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Model Millionaire
- **Where Written:** London, England
- **When Published:** 1887
- **Literary Period:** Aestheticism, Decadent Movement
- **Genre:** Short Story, Social Commentary
- **Setting:** London, England
- **Climax:** Baron Hausberg surprises Hughie with the money he needs to get married
- **Antagonist:** Poverty and elitism
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Irish Identity. While Wilde's name has become synonymous with wit and elegance, his Irish background made him a target for racist caricatures during his 1882 visit to the United States, where anti-Irish sentiment was still strong. Today, Ireland proudly claims Wilde as a highlight of their robust literary

tradition.



PLOT SUMMARY

Hughie Erskine is a romantic, hopelessly ignorant of the pragmatic truths of life in 1880s London. Good-natured, charming, and popular, he nevertheless has no head for business and no will to compete. He lives off a meager allowance from his aunt. Hughie and Laura Merton are in love, but Laura's father, the Colonel, forbids them to get married until Hughie has 10,000 pounds of his own. Hughie is accordingly depressed.

One day, Hughie visits his friend Alan Trevor—a painter—at his studio. Alan is painting an old beggar in rags, exulting in his fortune in finding such an expressive model. Pity for the ramshackle beggar seizes Hughie, who criticizes Alan's cynicism and argues that the beggar should receive some of the substantial fee that Alan's painting will fetch. When Alan steps out of the room, Hughie cannot resist giving his last **sovereign** to the beggar, figuring the man needs it more than he does. That afternoon, Laura sweetly reprimands his foolhardy generosity.

When Hughie runs into Alan again later that night at a club, Alan reveals that the beggar asked him all about Hughie after he left. Hughie continues to worry about the beggar, while Alan doubles down on his claim that the romantic image of the man's poverty outweighs the misery he must feel in experiencing it. Hughie again accuses him of cynicism. Alan defends artists' duty to art above social reform and adds that he told the beggar all about Hughie's financial and romantic straits. This enrages Hughie, prompting Alan to finally reveal that the beggar is actually the millionaire Baron Hausberg, who requested to be painted in beggar's clothes. A shocked Hughie reveals with dismay that he foolishly gave the man a coin, which makes Alan laugh hysterically.

The next morning, a messenger from the Baron arrives at Hughie's house. Assuming that the Baron was insulted by his donation, Hughie starts to apologize. In fact, the messenger has come bearing a check for 10,000 pounds—"from an old beggar"—as repayment for Hughie's generosity. Finally financially secure, Hughie marries Laura, and Alan is his best man. Baron Hausberg gives a speech at the wedding.

gentle nature has made him useless at all the jobs he's tried. His resulting poverty stands in the way of his one desire: to marry his love, Laura Merton. Laura's Father, the Colonel, is as fond of Hughie as everyone else, but he insists that Hughie have his own fortune before marrying Laura. Hughie's character exposes a paradox in London society: his simplicity and generous personality, for which he is so widely admired, impede his ability to succeed economically in a cutthroat society, thus barring him from enjoying all its privileges—like romance. His painter friend Alan Trevor, by contrast, adopts a cynical stance in his art and is paid handsomely for it. Yet, Hughie's generosity ultimately saves him: a beggar modelling for Alan, to whom Hughie gives one of his precious last coins, turns out to be the millionaire Baron Hausberg in disguise. The Baron is touched by Hughie's generosity and gives him all the money he needs to marry Laura. Hughie's fate thus disproves his society's dismissal of lofty emotion as useless for the non-wealthy: Hughie's outsized generosity is precisely what wins him fantastic wealth.

Alan Trevor – Alan Trevor, Hughie's friend, is a talented painter. Somewhat odd-looking and crude-mannered, Alan nevertheless earns both respect and substantial fees for his masterful paintings. Despite his own rough looks and thorny personality, Alan believes artists like himself should surround themselves with beautiful and vacuous people—a goal that initially drew him to the handsome Hughie. Eventually, however, he came to admire Hughie's good-natured generosity in addition to his looks. When Hughie visits Alan's studio and laments the condition of the old beggar modelling for Alan that day, Alan counters that the man's sorry condition is the raw material for artistic gold. He doubles down on this position in a further argument with Hughie that night, proclaiming that an artist's job is merely to depict the world, not to improve it. Yet Alan's aloofness proves disingenuous once he reveals that the model was no beggar but actually a millionaire, his friend Baron Hausberg. When the Baron gives Hughie the funds to marry Laura, Alan serves as Hughie's best man. Alan's bold theoretical declamations—and his mischievous insincerity in delivering them—mark him as a layered, intellectual character who highlights by contrast Hughie's simple, earnest good-naturedness.

The Beggar (Baron Hausberg) – Baron Hausberg is one of the wealthiest and most powerful men in Europe. He is also a friend and patron of Alan's, and he has commissioned Alan to paint him as a beggar. Hughie, ignorant of Hausberg's real identity, sees the man in beggar's rags when he visits Alan's studio and gives him one of his last coins out of pity. In his disguise, Hausberg thanks Hughie deeply. He then asks Alan all about Hughie after he leaves, learning of his financial and romantic difficulties. Hausberg is clearly moved by Hughie's generosity and decides to repay him. He sends a messenger to Hughie the next day carrying a check for all the money he needs to wed



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Hughie Erskine – Hughie Erskine is the story's protagonist, a young man in 1880s London society. His soft-hearted, romantic personality stands in contrast to the hardheaded social realities of his day, where romance is a privilege of the rich. Charming, attractive, and broadly popular, Hughie is a simple soul whose

Laura. At the marriage, he gives a speech. His exemplary behavior prompts Alan to dub him a “model millionaire.”

Laura Merton – Laura Merton is the young woman Hughie loves. Their love is mutual, and together they make one of London’s most attractive couples. She clearly loves Hughie for his personality, only lightheartedly scolding him after he heedlessly gives the beggar his last coin. Yet her father, the Colonel, forbids her to marry Hughie until Hughie has 10,000 pounds to his name, despite his affection for the young man.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Colonel Merton – The Colonel is Laura’s father, a retired veteran of service in India. His army experience has left him crabby, but Hughie’s universal charm manages to win even the Colonel’s affection. However, he pragmatically insists that Hughie have 10,000 pounds in hand before he even consider marrying Laura.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



APPEARANCE VS. REALITY

“The Model Millionaire” is full of deceptive appearances. Physical attractiveness goes a long way in late-19th-century London society: Hughie

Erskine’s good looks make him widely admired, but he lacks brilliance and ambition. His friend Alan Trevor, meanwhile, is an unattractive “strange rough fellow” but a brilliant artist who reaps financial success from his work. Although the characters seem to invest themselves in the idea that appearances bring themselves to bear on wealth and success, the lives they lead don’t necessarily support this idea. In fact, the story challenges the notion that appearances count for much at all.

Hughie and Alan disagree over the true reality of what they see, specifically in the case of a beggar modeling for Alan’s painting. Hughie laments the man’s poor condition, but Alan replies, “What you call rags I call romance. What seems poverty to you is picturesqueness to me.” The idea here is that Alan aesthetically romanticizes suffering and hardship while Hughie considers the reality of such things and what it would be like to actually experience them. Yet the whole debate rests on a false appearance: the beggar model is actually the millionaire, Baron Hausberg, who commissioned the portrait. Alan’s apparent cynicism thus turns out to be an accurate description of Hausberg’s own romantic request.

Ultimately, the story undercuts the importance of superficial things like appearance or status, as the attractive but seemingly insubstantial Hughie shows himself to be good to the core by giving the disguised Hausberg his last **sovereign**. And Hausberg, in turn, eschews typical wealthy pretensions and greed by handsomely repaying Hughie, thus proving himself a “model millionaire.” Hughie’s fortunate outcome demonstrates that, for Wilde, what matters is how people behave, not necessarily how they present themselves.



ARTISTS AND SOCIETY

In “The Model Millionaire,” Wilde examines the social function of artists, posing questions about their responsibility when it comes to depicting the

world around them. Alan Trevor, for his part, confidently declares that artists should simply depict the world “as [they] see it, not [...] reform it as [they] know it.” In other words, he suggests that art is purely representational—an impartial reflection of its subject matter.

At first, Alan’s perspective seemingly aligns with his callous remarks about the beggar who sits as a model for one of his paintings. Hughie is shocked that his friend doesn’t plan to pay the beggar very well for modeling, especially since Alan will undoubtedly make quite a bit of money from the painting. However, the story complicates Alan’s supposedly detached views about art when it’s revealed that the “beggar” is actually the millionaire who commissioned the painting in the first place. Although Alan claimed that artists should simply depict the world “as [they] see it,” he has manipulated reality by painting a millionaire dressed as a beggar. Of course, this is how he “see[s]” the world, but only because he has staged the scene.

The story doesn’t explicitly unpack the implications of Alan’s contradictory behavior. However, it’s possible Wilde is hinting that it’s difficult to make art with true objective detachment. Although artists might like the idea of simply depicting the world as it presents itself, the mere act of creation requires a certain level of interpretation (and, thus, manipulation) that ultimately involves the artist in the surrounding world. To remain completely aloof and passive, then, is harder than it might seem.



GENEROSITY AND COMPASSION

In “The Model Millionaire,” Wilde suggests that generosity and compassion are the most consequential traits a person can have. The story

opens with a catalogue of pragmatic “great truths of modern life,” asserting that romance and charm are privileges of the wealthy. Tenderhearted Hughie Erskine never learned these truths: both charming and romantic, he nevertheless subsists on a meager family allowance. He lacks the intellect and competitive edge to succeed in any of his attempted careers,

and though his charm and good looks gain him wide popularity, his poverty ensures his romantic disappointment: he cannot marry his love Laura without 10,000 pounds. At first, Hughie's "personal charm" attracts the painter Alan Trevor, but it is his "generous, reckless nature" that wins Alan's deeper friendship as well as permanent access to his studio. Significantly, this allows Hughie to be present when the millionaire Hausberg models as a beggar for Alan, a sight that compels Hughie to give the disguised Hausberg his last **sovereign**. Hughie's generosity is foolish from a practical perspective, impoverished as he is, but it ultimately earns him Hausberg's immense generosity in response. Perhaps surprisingly, the harsh "truths of modern life" still hold true at the story's end: romance and charm would have continued to bind Hughie to disappointment and, in this way, they remain wealthy luxuries. Greater intellect or competitive drive, Wilde implies, would not have changed Hughie's life for the better. In the end, it's Hughie's generous nature that triggers the chain of events that improves Hughie's life and brings him happiness.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE SOVEREIGN

Hughie's last sovereign (a gold coin) symbolizes his capacity to feel empathy for people whose circumstances are worse than his own. Overcome with pity at the sight of the beggar in Alan's studio (really the millionaire Baron Hausberg in costume), Hughie feels compelled to give the man some money. He feels around and finds only one sovereign, a coin of almost pure gold and worth a pound. Hughie knows that he can hardly afford to give the sovereign away, but he figures the beggar needs it more than he does. In this respect, the gold coin represents the magnanimous core of Hughie's character, of which he gives freely and even recklessly. When he learns the beggar's real identity, Hughie's main regret is just that he might have insulted the wealthy Baron with his sovereign. In fact, he has won the Baron's affection, and when the Baron repays him thousands of times over, Hughie is finally rewarded for his compassion and kindness.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Dover Publications edition of *The Canterville Ghost and Other Stories* published in 2001.

The Model Millionaire Quotes

☞ Unless one is wealthy there is no use in being a charming fellow. Romance is the privilege of the rich, not the profession of the unemployed. The poor should be practical and prosaic [...]. These are the great truths of modern life which Hughie Erskine never realised.

Related Characters: Hughie Erskine

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 30

Explanation and Analysis

The story opens with this catalogue of "great truths" to show the commonly held beliefs of 1880s London, where it takes place. Simply rattling off a list of these beliefs is a striking way to begin a story, and the tactic immediately invites readers to question whether or not the story itself supports those convictions. By first just stating them as fact and then stepping back and saying, "these are the great truths of modern life," the story calls attention to its own narrative voice, which suddenly adopts a certain distance from these beliefs (as opposed to the simple identification with them that it initially seemed to display).

The narrator's position in this opening, both inside and outside the society, thematically reflects Hughie's own, as presented here: Hughie doesn't recognize these "great truths" but is subjected to them, nonetheless. His charm and romance win him admiration but ultimately do him no good since he lacks wealth. This opening passage emphasizes Hughie's inability to fit neatly into social categories, and it gives context as to why that mismatch will cause him such distress.

☞ He had gone on the Stock Exchange for six months; but what was a butterfly to do among bulls and bears?

Related Characters: Hughie Erskine

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 30

Explanation and Analysis

This passage reemphasizes Hughie's gentle, romantic nature, showing how it has made him incompatible with the harsh and competitive world of business. By metaphorically referring to Hughie as a "butterfly," the story associates him

with butterflies' typical qualities of beauty, grace, and whimsy—as well, perhaps, as flimsiness or insubstantiality. This passage thus encourages the reader to consider whether charm, delicacy, and good looks are all there is to Hughie—like how butterflies are dazzlingly attractive and captivating but so thin that they are almost two-dimensional. As the story proceeds, it will undermine this initial, frivolous impression of Hughie and reveal the deep goodness of his character.

At any rate, a delicate creature like Hughie doesn't stand a chance in an environment like the Stock Exchange, where successful traders are brash and aggressive, like bulls and bears. This passage also engages in lighthearted wordplay: a "bull market" is an old expression for when stocks are performing well, and a "bear market" means the opposite. Wilde's metaphor cleverly points out that those figures of speech actually reflect the belligerent nature of stock traders.

☞ Trevor was a painter. Indeed, few people escape that nowadays. But he was also an artist, and artists are rather rare.

Related Characters: Alan Trevor

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 31

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the story pokes fun at the artistic pretensions of its day. Hughie's friend Alan Trevor is a painter, which is apparently quite a common career or pastime in 1880s London. By sardonically remarking that "few people escape" being a painter these days, the narrator implies both that fashioning oneself as an artist is something that ought to be avoided and that the allure of becoming an artist is seemingly irresistible.

Yet, unlike those masses of people who—the story implies—take up painting to cultivate some kind of self-image and cash in on the romantic stereotype of the artist, Alan Trevor actually is a masterful painter and, thus, that rare creature: a real "artist." It is significant that the story introduces Alan with this remark that draws a distinction between how he appears and what he actually is. As the story proceeds, Alan will offer his well-developed thoughts on this distinction, which is so fundamental to art. Ultimately, Alan's proclamation of his thoughts on that

duality will turn out to be themselves a kind of playfully deceptive appearance. Alan's character provides a lens for the story to explore the conflict between how things seem and what they really are.

☞ "Poor old chap!" said Hughie, "how miserable he looks! But I suppose, to you painters, his face is his fortune?"

"Certainly," replied Trevor, "you don't want a beggar to look happy, do you?"

Related Characters: Hughie Erskine, Alan Trevor (speaker), The Beggar (Baron Hausberg)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 31

Explanation and Analysis

When Hughie goes to visit Alan Trevor at his studio one day, he finds him in the middle of painting a man in beggar's clothes. While Hughie immediately expresses pity for the man, Alan only revels in his luck in finding a model with such an evocative appearance. This difference in reaction towards the man in rags suggests a fundamental difference in outlook between Hughie and Alan: Hughie's relationship to the world is sympathetic and involved, while Alan's seems cold and detached, only excited by the prospects for his own art.

Given the high payout that Alan will receive for this painting, it seems possible here that greed has merely momentarily clouded his sympathy, but his statement that a happy-looking beggar is positively undesirable reflects quite poorly on him. Hughie's later accusation that Alan is "heartless" seems justified here—that is, until Alan reveals that the beggar was no beggar at all. Considered in the light of that later revelation, Alan's callous remarks here seem perhaps to be a playful ruse, stringing Hughie along into believing that he really is heartless, just for his own amusement.

This passage also plays on the multiple meanings of the word "fortune" as both luck and wealth. To Hughie, the beggar's dejected appearance reveals both the man's bad luck in life and, literally, his personal wealth, or lack thereof. Yet, he recognizes that the beggar's unique appearance in fact represents a windfall of good luck for painters like Alan, who will turn that luck in finding the model into a literal cash fortune when selling his painting.

“It’s all very well, Hughie, for you to talk, but I assure you that there are moments when Art almost attains to the dignity of manual labour [...].”

Related Characters: Alan Trevor (speaker), Hughie Erskine

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 32

Explanation and Analysis

Hughie, fed up with Alan’s cynical attitude towards the beggar, suggests that the beggar should get some of the painting’s earnings since he works just as hard as Alan by standing still all day as a model. In this passage, Alan keeps up his playful cynicism while raising serious questions about the relation of art to work. In 19th-century London (as much as today), a commonly held prejudice was that making art is not “real” work in the way “manual labor” is. Alan, by half-jokingly saying there are only “moments” when art “almost” becomes as dignified as manual labor, seems to endorse that public perception and belittle his own craft.

This passage urges readers to consider whether artists truly occupy a privileged position within—or even outside of—the normal social order of work and prestige, being exempt from hard work by virtue of their inborn talent. And yet, deception and illusion are an integral part of the artist’s trade, and Alan engages in both throughout the story. Given what we know about him by the story’s end, it is justified here to question whether he genuinely believes in his belittling of artists’ work. In most cases, mastering and reliably performing an artistic craft in fact requires huge amounts of work, which Alan would know better than anyone.

“Poor old fellow,” he thought to himself, “he wants it more than I do, but it means no hansoms for a fortnight”; and he walked across the studio and slipped the sovereign into the beggar’s hand.

Related Characters: Hughie Erskine (speaker), The Beggar (Baron Hausberg)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 32

Explanation and Analysis

When Alan steps out of the room for a moment, Hughie gives free reign to his pity for the modelling beggar and decides to give him his last sovereign. This passage shows Hughie at what turns to be a fateful juncture that will change his life. Yet, for Hughie in the moment, the choice is an obvious one: he acknowledges that giving the beggar his coin will inconvenience him by using up all his cab fare for the next two weeks (“hansoms” are horse-drawn cabs), but he never seriously considers not doing it. His generous nature compels him.

This passage demonstrates for the first time that Hughie is not just some affable but frivolous charmer, as he may have seemed in the opening pages. By really trying to imagine another’s point of view (“he wants it more than I do”) and acting on his generous instinct without reservation, Hughie shows that his superficial charm and gentleness in fact go right down to his depths, where generosity and compassion compose the core of who he is. This passage introduces the symbol of the sovereign, a pure gold coin, to represent Hughie’s exemplary spirit, of which he gives so freely. The fact that Hughie is alone with the beggar and doesn’t know the man’s real identity underscores his pure desire to help, since as far as Hughie knows there is no one present to impress with his generosity.

“An artist’s heart is his head,” replied Trevor; “and besides, our business is to realise the world as we see it, not to reform it as we know it. *A chacun son métier*”

Related Characters: Alan Trevor (speaker), Hughie Erskine, The Beggar (Baron Hausberg)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 33

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Alan Trevor brings his seemingly cynical philosophy of art to full fruition. Having run into one another in a club, he and Hughie have been talking about the beggar from earlier in the day and debating what responsibility artists have towards society. When Hughie calls Alan heartless, Alan responds with the rather cryptic claim that an “artist’s heart is his head.” What this means isn’t exactly clear, but perhaps Alan is suggesting that artists express their heartfulness not through direct attempts to alleviate suffering but through the intellectual act of producing art, which captures the feelings of empathy that someone like Hughie simply acts on.

Alan's following statement reinforces this idea of the artist as a detached observer who gets to be exempt from societal woes by depicting them. "A *chacun son métier*," he says (French for "to each his own job"), distancing himself from the responsibility to help his fellow man. Yet his claim to realize the world "as [he] see[s] it" becomes ironic considering the later revelation that Alan's beggar model is in fact the millionaire Hausberg, something Alan knew all along. Indeed, the world as he saw it in that case featured a millionaire choosing to dress in beggar's clothes, but Alan knows that his depiction is disingenuous, and it undermines his claim of detached objectivity. By willfully "realizing" Hausberg's self-misrepresentation, Alan in fact "reforms" the world on the basic level of how things appear.

☞ "The old man you saw to-day in the studio was Baron Hausberg. He is a great friend of mine, buys all my pictures and that sort of thing, and gave me a commission a month ago to paint him as a beggar. *Que voulez-vous? La fantaisie d'un millionnaire!*"

Related Characters: Alan Trevor (speaker), The Beggar (Baron Hausberg)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 33

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Alan discloses the reality of the situation, completely upending his whole debate with Hughie, as well as Hughie's understanding of the whole day. By revealing the unexpected truth about the beggar's identity, Alan also reveals a new layer to his own character: his willingness to play along with Hughie's delusion for his own amusement. Simultaneously, Alan's surprise disclosure absolves him of the cynicism towards the downtrodden that Hughie previously accused him of—at least in this case. The story never clarifies why indeed Baron Hausberg commissioned his portrait as a beggar, but Alan's comment (in English: "What do you want? A Millionaire's Fantasy!") reveals that he hasn't thought too deeply about it himself and that the payout he's getting perhaps lets him look past the strange and somewhat problematic nature of Hausberg's request. Hausberg is in fact a "great friend" of Alan's, recalling Alan's earlier remark that painters should only hobnob with elites. The story urges the reader to ponder how Alan would have acted had he actually found a real beggar with such expressive features: would he have felt some of Hughie's

sympathy, or would he comport himself just the same?

☞ "I suppose he has come for an apology," said Hughie to himself; and he told the servant to show the visitor up.

Related Characters: Hughie Erskine (speaker), The Beggar (Baron Hausberg)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 34

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Hughie again unthinkingly demonstrates the depth of his compassion and concern for his fellow man. The day after the painting session, a messenger representing Baron Hausberg has arrived at Hughie's door. At this point, as far as Hughie knows, Hausberg is a millionaire who took Hughie's last coin without breaking his disguise—taking it, one might think, for no apparent reason. For all Hughie knows, Hausberg could have taken a sick delight in letting Hughie foolishly sink himself further into poverty.

Despite all this, Hughie's primary concern is that he may have insulted the Baron with his ignorance of the man's wealth, and he is prepared to profusely apologize. That this should be his reaction to the situation once again indicates that Hughie's generosity is essential to who he is and that he doesn't have a mean or even a suspicious bone in his body. This reaffirmation ties back to the narrator's statement in the opening paragraph that Hughie "never said a brilliant or even an ill-natured thing in his life." That line shows how in 1880s London, brilliance was considered correlated with mean-spiritedness. Hughie may be only averagely intelligent, but he doesn't have a drop of cruelty in him.

☞ "Millionaire models," remarked Alan, "are rare enough; but, by Jove, model millionaires are rarer still!"

Related Characters: Alan Trevor (speaker), The Beggar (Baron Hausberg)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 34

Explanation and Analysis

The messenger that Hausberg sent to Hughie turns out to

be carrying a check for 10,000 pounds, in appreciation of Hughie's generosity. Finally rich enough to marry Laura, Hughie holds a wedding where Baron Hausberg gives a toast, prompting this remark from Alan. This passage, which ends the story and also gives it its name, offers a concluding reassertion of the importance of generosity. While Hausberg's decision to model as a beggar was indeed unique, what really distinguishes him is his "model" behavior in liberally repaying Hughie's own generosity.

It is worth noting that this enthusiastic assessment comes

from Alan, whose own conduct has come under scrutiny repeatedly throughout the story. While the relative truthfulness or deceptiveness of Alan's cynical remarks earlier remains ambiguous, he certainly did not come off as a model of generosity. And yet, he was eventually drawn to Hughie by the "generous [...] nature" he recognized in him, so evidently it is a quality he values in others. Whether Alan himself will follow the Baron's "model" in life as he did in painting remains unknown.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

THE MODEL MILLIONAIRE

Hughie Erskine never learned that romance and charm are privileges of the rich. He has both romance and charm, but he lacks the money to back them up. Handsome, kind, and universally well-liked, he's nevertheless intellectually undistinguished and hopeless at business. He has tried and failed several careers and is seemingly too gentle for the working world.

Hughie loves Laura Merton, the daughter of a Colonel who admires Hughie but forbids their marriage until Hughie can come up with 10,000 pounds—a hopeless prospect for an unemployed person like Hughie.

Hughie goes to visit his friend Alan Trevor, an eccentric but brilliant painter who was drawn to Hughie's charm at first but then, later, to his "generous, reckless nature." While rather odd-looking himself, Alan nonetheless declares that "men who are dandies and women who are darlings" should run the world.

The story explicitly frames Hughie as a misfit in the unsentimental world of 1880s London. This society esteems the most superficial things in life—wealth and physical attractiveness. Being handsome but poor, Hughie lacks a clear place in this social structure. Paradoxically, his kindness and dreamy personality make him socially popular while ensuring that he will never get ahead in the cutthroat business world (and thus acquire the wealth that is necessary in this society to really enjoy romance). Hughie is stuck in an unfortunate position, but it's unclear at this point whether his sentimental demeanor indicates his genuine bigheartedness or just lazy mediocrity in a handsome package.



The Colonel embodies this society's contradictory set of values: he admires Hughie, presumably, for his looks and his gentleness, but he dismisses him for his poverty. As the enforcer of social expectations about wealth, the Colonel stands in the way of Hughie's romantic fulfillment.



Alan appears to exemplify this society's superficial glorification of good looks. He proclaims that "dandies"—a common term at the time used to refer to men who prioritized their own appearance—and beautiful, vapid "darlings" should hold all the power. And yet, Alan himself is unattractive, and his social status rests not on looks but on his mastery of painting. The story thus probes how the rules of social hierarchy apply to artists—if at all. It also invites readers not to take Alan at his word, foreshadowing later revelations that things are not what they appear. Alan's own fondness for Hughie likewise displays emphasizes the story's juxtaposition between the superficial and the truly meaningful, as he fixated first on Hughie's looks but eventually on his "generous" nature—the story's first sign that Hughie's goodness is deep and substantial, distinct from his superficial charm.



Today, the model sitting for Alan's painting is an old beggar in rags. Alan is enthralled with the man's expressive features and the artistic use he can make of them. Hughie expresses pity for the man and criticizes Alan for taking a high payout for his work while his model gets almost nothing. Alan lightheartedly counters that painting is hard work.

In this scene, the story reveals the depths of Hughie's compassion by pitting it against Alan's apparent callousness. Alan seems to believe that the beggar's suffering is just artistic raw material for him, whereas Hughie can't help but get drawn into the reality of that suffering. However, the flippancy with which Alan counters Hughie's serious criticisms again suggests that he may be withholding something.



When Alan steps out for a moment, Hughie is overcome with pity and gives the "forlorn" beggar his last **sovereign**, a donation he can hardly afford. The beggar thanks him deeply. Hughie then leaves to see Laura, who gently chides his generosity.

Here, Hughie proves that his kindness is more than just a cover for laziness: generosity lies deep in his core. His character is as pure as the sovereign (a coin of pure gold worth a pound) that he gives to the beggar. The story makes clear that there's nothing showy or insincere about Hughie's gift, since he's alone with the beggar and there's no one around to impress—or so it seems.



Later that night, Hughie walks into a club and sees Alan. Alan informs him that the model asked all about Hughie after he left. Hughie again expresses pity for the man, and Alan counters with an artist's perspective: "What you call rags I call romance." Hughie calls painters "a heartless lot."

From the beginning, the story has emphatically portrayed Hughie as a romantic. Yet, where Alan sees an artistic romance in the beggar, Hughie sees only misery. Alan doubles down on his denial that artists have any responsibility toward the world beyond turning it into art. This scene again seems to suggest that artists stand outside of the normal social structure: rough-edged and even "heartless," the unromantic Alan nevertheless claims to see romance in societal misery, implicitly because it doesn't affect him. An actual romantic like Hughie cannot romanticize poverty, on the other hand, since he experiences a version of it himself.



Alan says that he told the model all about Hughie's romantic and financial woes. A shocked Hughie feels violated until Alan reveals that the model is no beggar but is, in fact, Baron Hausberg, one of the richest men in Europe. Hughie is now even more embarrassed, revealing to Alan that he foolishly gave the Baron a **sovereign**. Alan laughs hysterically at Hughie's mistake, while half-jokingly ensuring him that it reflects highly on his "philanthropic spirit."

Alan's revelation pulls the rug out from beneath his whole exchange with Hughie. His cynical opinions take on a whole new and more playful light in retrospect, but he doesn't retract them. Rather, the story leaves readers with a sense of ambiguity regarding Alan's comments and behavior. The fact that he knowingly painted the Baron in disguise undermines his claim to merely take the world as it is and make art from it. Just as he deceives his future audience with the painting, he has deceived Hughie in conversation up to this point, and the beggar himself turns out to embody the untrustworthiness of appearances. Yet in this cascade of deceptions, Hughie's "philanthropic spirit" remains as simple and pure as the sovereign that symbolized it, despite his present embarrassment.



The next morning, a messenger on behalf of Baron Hausberg arrives at Hughie's house. Hughie immediately starts apologizing for presumably insulting the Baron, but the messenger interrupts to hand him a letter. It reads: "A wedding present to Hugh Erskine and Laura Merton, from an old beggar," and it contains a check for 10,000 pounds.

Hughie and Laura get married. Alan is the best man, and the Baron gives a speech. Alan declares that "millionaire models" are quite rare, but that "model millionaires are rarer still!"

Hughie's kindness extends even to the point of feeling that he owes an apology to the millionaire who took his last coin. In this final twist, the story shows how that unblemished goodness of heart ultimately rescues Hughie from the very difficulties which up until now it had created for him. His generosity disqualified him from the working world and finally cost him his last coin, but that final act reverses everything for him and realizes his dreams. If he had been anything less than good to the core, he would likely have succumbed to bitterness before ever meeting the disguised Baron.



Wilde plays on two related meanings of "model" here: as someone who poses for an artist, and as someone whose behavior is exemplary (after whom others may "model" their own lives). The Baron's disguise turns out to have been twofold: not only was he not a beggar, but also, he lacked any of the expected greed or pretensions of a millionaire. In fact, he has as much of a "generous, reckless nature" as Hughie.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Cahill, Ciaran. "*The Model Millionaire*." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 28 Dec 2023. Web. 28 Dec 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Cahill, Ciaran. "*The Model Millionaire*." LitCharts LLC, December 28, 2023. Retrieved December 28, 2023.
<https://www.litcharts.com/lit/the-model-millionaire>.

To cite any of the quotes from *The Model Millionaire* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Wilde, Oscar. *The Model Millionaire*. Dover Publications. 2001.

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Wilde, Oscar. *The Model Millionaire*. Mineola: Dover Publications. 2001.